

Miles between matches

FROM TUBE STATIONS AND CRICKET GROUNDS TO INTERESTING ENCOUNTERS WITH STRANGERS, OUR CORRESPONDENT SHARES VIGNETTES FROM HIS TRAVELS ACROSS ENGLAND DURING THE ICC WOMEN'S T20 WORLD CUP.

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As you get off at the Oval tube station and move towards one of the world's most famous cricket grounds, just a couple of minutes away, you find a deep blue-and-purple team bus for the ICC Women's T20 World Cup. But it cannot be India's, of course. The Women in Blue were knocked out the previous afternoon by the magnificent Australians.

Captain Harmanpreet Kaur gave India a chance with a stunning knock. She tends to reserve her best for Australia. But Ellyse Perry and Ashleigh Gardner came up with a brilliantly crafted century partnership to take their team

comfortably past the Indian total, which was competitive considering the opposition. The Indian innings lacked momentum and planning. Something is not right when your best finisher gets to face just one ball.

The organisers, too, would have been a bit disappointed with India's early exit. India is by far the biggest market for women's cricket, and it continues to grow rapidly.

A few million more eyeballs would have followed the knockout stages had India remained in the competition. India also had a strong following at the grounds, with fans from different parts of the UK and even overseas travelling to Birmingham, Leeds, Manchester and London.

Sometimes on foreign shores,

you come across the 'milk of human kindness'. (It is only fair to quote Shakespeare while reporting from England, right?)

In Manchester, you have to travel to the ground to watch the Indian team's training session ahead of the match against South Africa. It isn't difficult to figure out commuting in the UK using your phone, but sometimes, especially on your first day in a new city, you need to speak to people, as you used to in the good old days before Google or ChatGPT.

At a station from where you can catch either a tram or a bus to Old Trafford, you ask someone for directions. There is also a press conference to attend, and you don't have a lot of time on your hands.

Darren is coming out of the Morrisons supermarket and tells you that you could wait for a bus. "I am a